Biodynamic Agriculture

Farms, training, books and where to start

Please note. Biodynamic farming rests on Rudolf Steiner's spiritual science. The preparations and the planting calendar are used and reported on by farmers; their effects are not settled by conventional agricultural research. The listings below are for orientation and do not endorse any individual farm or business.

I. What biodynamic agriculture is

Biodynamic agriculture is a form of organic farming that treats the farm as one living organism. Fields, livestock, woodland, compost and garden are meant to support each other, with as few outside inputs as possible. It is the oldest organic growing system, and it grew directly out of Steiner's anthroposophy. The movement marked its hundredth year in 2024.

Biodynamic land grew by 57% in ten years, to 255,000 hectares in 2022, farmed by more than 7,000 farmers in 63 countries. The movement also reports about 33% more species on biodynamic farms than on conventionally farmed land.

- **The preparations.** Numbered 500 to 508, they are made from medicinal plants, minerals and animal materials and used in very small amounts on soil, compost and plants. Preparation 500 (horn manure) is cow manure packed into a cow horn and buried over winter, then stirred in water and sprayed on the soil to support root growth and soil life. Preparation 501 (horn silica) is ground quartz packed into a horn and buried over summer, then stirred and sprayed on plants to support photosynthesis and plant quality.
- **The planting calendar.** Biodynamic farmers time sowing, cultivation and harvest by the position of the moon and planets. Root days fall when the moon is in earth constellations, flower days in air, fruit days in fire, and leaf days in water. Maria Thun worked on the calendar for more than fifty years, and it is still published every year by Floris Books.
- **Why horns.** Steiner described the cow's horns as organs that gather cosmic forces and direct them back into the animal. That is the reasoning behind packing the preparations in horn. Farmers who use them report healthier soil and plants, but conventional trials have not established this.
- **Certification.** Demeter is the certifier for biodynamic farms and products, and its standards require use of the preparations. In the United States the whole farm must be certified, not a single crop, and it is inspected every year. demeter.net

II. Where it began: the Agriculture Course, 1924

After the First World War, many European soils were worn out and farmers were seeing poorer seed and food, with more disease in crops and animals. A group of farmers and gardeners asked Steiner repeatedly for guidance. He gave eight lectures at Koberwitz (now Kobierzyce, Poland) between 7 and

16 June 1924, around Whitsun, on the estate of Count and Countess Keyserlingk. They were published as the Agriculture Course, GA 327. The Rudolf Steiner Archive lists it under the title *Spiritual Science Foundations for the Prosperity of Agriculture*.

Count Keyserlingk proposed that experiments begin right away, and the farmers formed an agricultural working group. Steiner cautioned that anyone hoping for a list of easily made preparations that pay off quickly would misunderstand the course. The first agricultural conference was held at the Goetheanum in 1925, and one has been held every year since.

- **Read it free.** The full text of the Agriculture Course is online at rsarchive.org. Print editions come from SteinerBooks, Floris Books and Rudolf Steiner Press.

III. How to find a farm in your country

- **Worldwide.** Demeter International keeps the directory of Demeter-certified farms in its 63 member countries. Search by country, product or region at demeter.net under "Find Farms" or "Members".
- **USA.** Demeter USA lists certified farms, dairies, wineries and processors at demeter-usa.org. DemeterLOCAL links community groups that support biodynamic farms within 200-mile regional food sheds. The Biodynamic Association gives members a farm directory (biodynamics.com), and localharvest.org lists CSA farms and farmers markets.
- **UK and Ireland.** The Biodynamic Association lists certified farms, veg boxes and products, and supports Demeter certification. biodynamic.org.uk
- **Germany.** Search by postcode and product type at demeter.de/produkte-kaufen.
- **Australia.** Biodynamic Agriculture Australia runs a farm directory, training and preparation sales at biodynamics.net.au. Certified products are listed at demeterorganic.com.au.
- **New Zealand.** Find farms through Demeter International (demeter.net/members) or the Biodynamic Farming and Gardening Association of NZ.
- **Brazil and South America.** Instituto Biodinamico (IBD) is the main certifier in South America, with producer listings for Brazil and the wider region. ibd.com.br
- **South Africa.** A growing number of certified farms and wine estates, found through demeter.net/members. Waterkloof, Reyneke and Stellar Organics are among the best known.
- **India.** A sizeable and growing movement, mostly in the southern states, with several certified farms and tea gardens. Contact Demeter International or the Organic Farming Association of India for producer listings.
- **CSA farms.** In Community Supported Agriculture, families buy a weekly box of vegetables straight from a local farm. Search for "biodynamic CSA" plus your area. In the USA use localharvest.org; in Europe each national Demeter organisation keeps its own list; in Australia see biodynamics.net.au.

IV. Germany

Germany has one of the largest biodynamic movements in the world, with hundreds of Demeter-certified farms, dairies, bakeries, wineries and food producers.

- **Demeter Deutschland e.V..** Darmstadt. The national Demeter organisation, with a farm and product finder. demeter.de
- **Rapunzel Naturkost.** Legau, Bavaria. An organic food company founded in 1974, selling nuts, dried fruit, grains, pasta and chocolate, many of them Demeter-certified. rapunzel.de
- **Alnatura.** Darmstadt. An organic supermarket chain with more than 140 stores, started in the anthroposophical spirit, with a strong Demeter range. It is often used by Waldorf families. alnatura.de
- **Forschungsring fur Biologisch-Dynamische Wirtschaftsweise e.V..** Darmstadt. The German biodynamic research institute, working on farming methods, preparations, soil biology and food quality. Publishes annual research reports. forschungsring.de

V. Farms and estates worth knowing

- **Hawthorne Valley Farm.** Ghent, New York. Next to Hawthorne Valley Waldorf School. CSA, raw dairy, bakery, sauerkraut, farm store, open days, apprenticeships and workshops. One of the most visited biodynamic farms in North America. hawthornevalleyfarm.org
- **Apricot Lane Farms.** Moorpark, California. The farm in the film *The Biggest Little Farm*, with orchards, livestock and composting. Visits and CSA. apricotlanefarms.com
- **Threefold Community Farm.** Chestnut Ridge, New York. On the Threefold anthroposophical campus. Vegetables and eggs, and a yearly training programme. threefoldcommunityfarm.org
- **Emerson College Farm.** Forest Row, East Sussex, England. A working farm for the college, with vegetables and livestock. Students take part in the farm work. emerson.ac.uk
- **Waterkloof Wine Estate.** Somerset West, South Africa. Demeter-certified, with horse-drawn ploughing and the full set of preparations. waterkloofwines.co.za
- **Demeter Farm.** Dandenong, Victoria, Australia. Founded in 1934 by Ileen Macpherson and Ernesto Genoni as the first biodynamic farm in Australia and the first in the Southern Hemisphere to use the Demeter name.
- **Escola AITIARA / Estancia Demetria.** Botucatu, Sao Paulo, Brazil. A biodynamic farm joined to a Waldorf school, founded in 1984. aitiara.org.br
- **Domaine Leflaive.** Puligny-Montrachet, Burgundy, France. A Demeter-certified estate producing Grand Cru Burgundy biodynamically.
- **Bio-Dynamic Research Institute.** Powelltown, Victoria, Australia. Research centre that makes and distributes preparations in Australia and abroad. bdri.com.au

VI. Biodynamic wine

Wine is the most visible side of biodynamics for many people, and several well-regarded estates farm this way. Regions to look at include Burgundy (Domaine Leflaive, Domaine Leroy), the Loire (Nicolas Joly), Alsace, the Rhone, South Africa (Waterkloof, Reyneke), the USA (Benziger, Fetzer Bonterra), Australia and New Zealand. Some producers use the Thun calendar to choose days for bottling and tasting. Nicolas Joly's *Wine from Sky to Earth* is a standard book on biodynamic viticulture. Demeter

wine producers are listed at demeter.net.

VII. Workshops and training

- **Agriculture Conference, Goetheanum.** Dornach, Switzerland. Held every year since 1925. The 2025 conference ran 5 to 8 February with more than 700 participants from 47 countries, on the theme "The Earth as a Living Being." The 2026 conference, 4 to 7 February, was titled "You Never Farm Alone." agriculture-conference.org and sektion-landwirtschaft.org
- **Biodynamic Association (USA).** Webinars, courses and an annual conference that moves around the country. A twelve-lesson course mixes practical, artistic and inner exercises, and students can start at any time and go at their own pace. A Farmer Foundation Year gives a full year of training in biodynamic farm management. biodynamics.com
- **Threefold Community Farm.** Chestnut Ridge, New York. A one-year part-time practical course in thirteen full-day workshops from September to June, led by Mac Mead and guest teachers. It covers the Agriculture Course, preparations, compost, soil, large animals, beekeeping and greenhouse work. Scholarships available. threefoldcommunityfarm.org
- **Pfeiffer Center Biodynamic Course.** Massachusetts, through NOFA/Mass. One-day workshops from September to April, named for Ehrenfried Pfeiffer, one of Steiner's agricultural colleagues. Partial scholarships and a certificate of completion. nofamass.org
- **Josephine Porter Institute.** USA. Has supported biodynamic gardeners and farmers since 1985 with preparations, workshops, books and research. Publishes the quarterly *Applied Biodynamics*. jpibiodynamics.org
- **Hawthorne Valley Farm.** Ghent, New York. Farm apprenticeships, workshops and open farm days. hawthornevalleyfarm.org
- **Emerson College.** Forest Row, East Sussex, England. Founded in 1962. One-year and shorter programmes in biodynamic agriculture, Goethean science, art and Waldorf education. emerson.ac.uk
- **Demeter International.** Coordinates training across its member countries, and each national Demeter body offers local courses, certification workshops and farm visits. demeter.net/services/biodynamic-training
- **Asia.** An annual training and networking conference for practitioners in Asia, held most recently in October 2024. The movement is growing in India, Japan, South Korea, China and Southeast Asia. Ask Demeter International for current contacts.
- **Scandinavia.** Training, workshops and a farm network across Denmark, Sweden, Norway and Finland, reached through the Nordic members of Demeter International. demeter.net/members

VIII. Books

- **Agriculture Course (GA 327), Rudolf Steiner.** The eight lectures from Koberwitz and the main text of biodynamics. In print from SteinerBooks, Floris Books and Rudolf Steiner Press, and free at rsarchive.org.

- **The Biodynamic Sowing and Planting Calendar, Maria Thun.** Floris Books, new each year. Gives root, flower, fruit and leaf days by the moon's position, and is the usual practical companion to the Agriculture Course. florisbooks.co.uk
- **Gardening for Life: The Biodynamic Way, Maria Thun.** Floris Books. A plain introduction for home gardeners covering preparations, the calendar, soil and composting.
- **Farming with the Cosmic Forces, Rudolf Steiner.** SteinerBooks. Selected lectures on biodynamic agriculture, shorter than the full course.
- **Soil and Soul, Alastair McIntosh.** Aurum Press. Not specifically biodynamic, but read in biodynamic circles. About land, community and spirituality.

IX. For families and home gardeners

- **Planting calendar.** Even without the preparations, many home gardeners sow and tend by the Thun calendar. It is sold through Waldorf book suppliers and florisbooks.co.uk.
- **Turtle Tree Seed.** USA. A small non-profit seed company selling open-pollinated vegetable, herb and flower seed, non-GMO and grown without chemical inputs. turtletreeseed.org
- **Josephine Porter Institute.** Sells biodynamic preparations by mail for people who cannot make their own, and is the main North American source. jpibiodynamics.org
- **Holle.** Founded in Switzerland in 1934 as the first Demeter-certified baby food brand. About 80% of its products worldwide carry the Demeter seal. holleusa.com and holle.ch
- **Weleda.** Has kept a biodynamic medicinal plant garden since 1921, the year the company was founded. weleda.com